

Trump relaxes carmaker tariffs

The president signs executive orders to ease some of his 25% levies on automobiles and parts for them.

By Josh Boak
and Alexa St. John

WASHINGTON — President Trump signed executive orders Tuesday to relax some of his 25% tariffs on automobiles and auto parts, the White House said, a significant reversal as the import taxes threatened to hurt domestic manufacturers.

Automakers and independent analyses have indicated that the tariffs could raise prices, reduce sales and make U.S. production less competitive worldwide. Trump portrayed the changes as a bridge toward automakers moving more production into the United States.

“We just wanted to help them during this little transition, short term,” Trump told reporters. “We didn’t want to penalize them.”

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, who spoke earlier at a White House briefing Tuesday, said the goal was to enable automakers to create more domestic manufacturing jobs.

“President Trump has had meetings with both domestic and foreign auto producers, and he’s committed to bringing back auto production to the U.S.,” Bessent said. “So we want to give the automakers a path to do that, quickly, efficiently and create as many jobs as possible.”

The administration will offer automakers that finish their vehicles domestically a 15% rebate this year, offsetting the cost of the tariffs. That rebate would be 10% the second year, giving the automakers some time to relocate production of parts

[See **Automakers**, A7]



JON CHERRY Associated Press

THE NATIONAL Climate Assessment report details the latest science on climate change and looks at progress in addressing global warming. In Frankfort, Ky., people navigate floodwaters at a distillery this month.

A new political fight over civil rights

By Kevin Rector

California’s two U.S. senators have joined with Democratic colleagues to demand answers from the Trump loyalist and Californian now heading the Justice Department’s Civil Rights Division, amid reports that she and other officials have pushed out senior leaders and imposed hard-right policies at odds with the department’s mission.

In a letter sent Friday to Assistant Atty. Gen. Harmeet Dhillon, seven senators — including Alex Padilla and Adam Schiff of California — cited reports that Dhillon had emailed directives changing long-standing enforcement goals to employees, including in sections that are “meant to protect voting rights, prevent discrimination by federal funding recipients, investigate illegal bias in housing, prohibit discrimination in education, and defend the rights of those with disabilities.”

Those directives “may well be inconsistent” with the intent of Congress when it passed legislation standing up the division, the senators wrote, and must be disclosed to them for review by Thursday.

The senators also referred to reports that multiple career lawyers and supervisors in the unit have left or been reassigned, that

[See **Civil rights**, A7]

Democrats accuse Trump loyalist of wrecking an enforcement unit. She says she’s targeting ‘woke’ ideology.



TOM WILLIAMS CQ-Roll Call

ASSISTANT Atty. Gen. Harmeet Dhillon says she expects Justice Department attorneys to enforce President Trump’s agenda.



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

TONY LAM, 88, was elected to the Westminster City Council in 1992, becoming the first of a stream of Vietnamese Americans to win political office in the U.S.

COLUMN ONE

Politician was an original influencer in O.C.’s Little Saigon — and he still is

By Anh Do

The textured mat is already on the table as Tony Lam sits down to shuffle the polished tiles. He is here to participate in a ritual that he observes four days a week, a pursuit that keeps his “head in shape.”

On this day, sitting in his

daughter’s house, he is competing against his wife, son-in-law and grandson, all of whom build a wall of game pieces in front of them.

It’s mah-jongg o’clock, and he’s ready.

One by one, they roll the dice to begin their match, dealing and betting a collection of quarters. Lam, quietly fierce with a booming laugh, studies the spread, and then ... his cellphone

pings. The original influencer of Little Saigon has been invited to another event — one of dozens each year — a commemoration of the Vietnamese immigration experience in America.

He snares a suite of tiles and wins a coin within 11 minutes. Nothing seems to faze him. But as he prepares to make his next move ... ping! It’s an invitation to an

[See **Lam**, A8]

Outcry over thousands of false positive opioid tests in state’s prisons

Incorrect results could taint parole decisions for some California inmates now and in future, advocates say.

By Salvador Hernandez

Thousands of inmates wrongly tested positive for opiate use inside California state prisons last year because of a laboratory mistake, and civil rights attorneys now worry many of them could be denied parole and a chance at freedom because of it.

About 6,000 drug tests are believed to have generated false positive results in 2024, according to attorneys at UnCommon Law, a non-profit advocacy group that represents inmates seeking parole. The organization confirmed the false test results through a series of public records requests, which showed positive test results suddenly spiked across California prisons between April and July last year.

The tests were done as

part of inmates’ drug treatment programs and included in their medical records, but attorneys representing the prisoners said the test results were also included in inmates’ parole hearing records as a result, meaning hundreds or thousands of parole hearings could be unfairly swayed by incorrect test results.

“Part of the problem is we don’t know the full scope of how it has impacted people,” said Natasha Baker, an attorney with UnCommon Law. “We believe several of our clients have been turned down.”

California Correctional Health Care Services, which provides healthcare to inmates in the state’s 31 prisons, notified the California Department of Corrections and Rehabilitation about the incorrect tests after it discovered a significant increase in the number of presumptive positive tests between April and July 2024, according to a statement from the corrections department.

The false positives came from urine drug tests given to prisoners undergoing

[See **False positive**, A14]

Climate report’s experts given the boot

Dismissals of 400 scientists raise fear Trump could end the effort or enlist others to attack the findings.

By Ian James
and Hayley Smith

The Trump administration this week summarily dismissed more than 400 scientists and other experts who had begun to write the latest National Climate Assessment report, informing them by email that the scope of the report was being re-evaluated.

The report, mandated by Congress, is prepared every four years under a 1990 law. It details the latest science on climate change, and also reports on progress in addressing global warming.

Scientists said they fear the Trump administration could seek to shut down the effort or enlist other authors to write a very different report that aims to attack climate science — a path they say would leave the country ill-prepared for worsening disasters intensified by humanity’s warming of the planet, including more intense heat waves, wildfires, droughts, floods and sea-level rise.

“Climate change puts us all at risk, and we all need this vital information to help prepare,” said Katharine Hayhoe, a climate scientist at Texas Tech University who was an author of four previous versions of the report, including three times as a lead author. “Without it, the future will be much more dangerous.”

She noted that although the assessment is required by law, there aren’t specific requirements about who exactly should write the report or the form it should take.

“It could end up being a collection of long-debunked myths and disinformation about climate change,” Hayhoe said. “It could end up being a document that is just not useful, does not serve the purpose of providing in-

[See **Climate**, A11]

County workers begin striking

Union says the two-day labor action comes after a failure to agree on a new contract.

CALIFORNIA, B1

Amazon won’t list tariff costs

White House sees plan to disclose charges on the giant retailer’s discount site as a “hostile act.”

BUSINESS, A10

Late games for Clippers, Kings

For full coverage of Game 5 against the Nuggets and Oilers, go to the eNewspaper and latimes.com/sports.

Weather
Turning sunny.
L.A. Basin: 72/55. **B6**

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